MCP
Mushroom Cloud Press
Speech Scripts

Classic Prose Collection

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Permission for performance of these stories is granted for the purpose of performance in competition by middle school, high school, and undergraduate collegiate performers.

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Classic Prose Collection

Sixteen delightful short stories from legendary writers, selected for uniqueness, character, and suitability for performance. We sorted through hundreds of classic tales to find great short stories that are perfect for modern audiences and young performers, but not clichéd or overdone.

These stories can all be cut to range in time from 5-10 minutes when performed, depending on the performer and their cutting. Many are already the perfect length for competition. All subject matter is well-suited for both middle school and high school competitors. Authors include J.M. Barrie, H.G. Wells, H.H. Munro, Lucy Maud Montgomery, Kurt Vonnegut, and more.

Story Summaries

Exclusive!
Several Trojan Skirmishes and One Wooden Animal
By Clyde Hendrickson
This light and uproarious take on the Trojan War follows several ill-fated warriors and kings, such as Heckuva, Ondajon, and Tendinitis, as they fight their way into comical infamy. Zeus is a standup comedian, Paris is as dumb as ever, and a giant wooden guinea pig… full of more guinea pigs… brings the war to its shocking conclusion. Easy for any performer to cut to suit their talents.

Exclusive!
A War Worth Fighting
By Clyde Hendrickson
The Bonglejohns and Needlenorfs pass their days flinging flaming rodents at each other across the border of their otherwise peaceful lands. These dwarves have not a care in the world until a meddling human named Tom shows up determined to force them into an awful peace. Clyde Hendrickson's dry wit and keen perception of human nature is on display in this satire of those people who just can't help trying to fix everything.

2 B R 0 2 B
By Kurt Vonnegut Jr.
In this dark comedy, Vonnegut's trademark wit turns a utopian world where no one has to die into a very chilling place. For when new children are born into this world, room must be made for them – by any means necessary.

The Feast of Nemesis
by Saki
"There is no outlet for demonstrating your feelings towards people whom you simply loathe." A clever story of one person's desire to have a day where, instead of heaping presents upon those you love, you give the most annoying people in life exactly what they deserve. This short, light comedy will allow a performer to portray the best and worst of high society.

Gabriel-Ernest
by Saki
Werewolves can be rather clever and charming, even if they've spent most of their lives in the woods. In this humorous tale of civilized horror, a local official finds a

boy living in the woods near his house, and soon finds himself in conversation and collusion with a monster.

The Girl at the Gate
by Lucy Maud Montgomery
Written by the author of Anne of Green Gables, this poetic ghost story weaves a romantic tale with beautiful detail and elegant narration. Novice prose performers will find much to work with here as they learn to grab an audience's attention with a classic story of lost love found again.

The Inconsiderate Waiter
by J.M. Barrie
The longest story in the collection -- but it can be cut in so many interesting ways. What happens when a waiter in a fashionable club speaks out of place? More than the uppity narrator bargained for! Brilliant satire from the creator of *Peter Pan*.

The Magic Shop
by H.G. Wells
Out for a walk in London one day, Gip and his father happen upon a magic shop. At Gip's urging, the two go in — and things grow more and more curious by the minute. Counters, store fixtures, and mirrors seem to move around the room, and the shopkeeper is most mysterious of all. Gip is thrilled by all he sees, but his father is no longer sure where reality ends and illusion begins.

My Brother Henry
by J.M. Barrie
Why is the narrator of this cheeky comedy so happy to have killed his own brother? Because he had invented the imaginary fellow years ago to get out of an inconvenient conversation. A lighthearted tale full of quick wit and fun.

The Outcasts of Poker Flat
by Bret Harte
Upon waking from their overnight camp in the mountains, four exiles from Poker Flat and a young couple traveling to the town face a snowstorm with limited provisions. The deadly result will leave a lasting impression on your audience.

The Queen of Spades
by Alexander Pushkin

Greed leads to madness in this ghost story with a moral. A young man seeks out a countess who holds the secret to winning a fortune at cards… but when he causes her death, the secret turns out to be a curse.

Thrond
by Bjornstjerne Bjornson

Two Friends
by Guy de Maupassant
Two old chums in Paris fish while the city is under siege. In a coincidence of melancholy poetry, they are given the chance to prove their friendship to the end.